

SUB 18-MIN 5K TRAINING PLAN

Hey there — Thomas from Marathon Handbook here. Thanks for taking the time to grab a copy of this plan!

As the name suggests, this plan has been built around the goal of running a 5K in under 18 minutes.

For a full breakdown of the strategy we recommend, check out the article this plan comes from: [How To Run A Sub-18 5K](#)

ARE YOU READY TO TAKE ON THIS PLAN?

This 6-week plan is for strong club-level runners chasing the 18-minute barrier. You should be training consistently, comfortable running roughly 40 minutes at an easy effort, and experienced with interval sessions on the track. If you're currently racing 5Ks in the mid-18s, this plan will help you sharpen the final edge.

TRAINING METHODS

Since we are aiming for a specific time goal, this plan combines two training methods: Rate of Perceived Exertion and Pace Training.

Rate of Perceived Exertion (RPE) is a method of training based on perception, or how you feel. The scale ranges from 1 to 10, with 1 being extremely comfortable and 10 being an all-out sprint.

Pace Training, on the other hand, is all about maintaining a specific pace, measured in minutes per kilometer or mile, for specific intervals or runs. It's like setting a rhythm for your body to follow, ensuring you stay on track towards your time goal.

For a sub-18 5K, your race pace is 5:47 / mile or 3:36 / km.

BREAKDOWN OF TRAINING WORKOUTS

Warm Up

Warm up before any workout that involves changes in pace or effort level, such as intervals, tempo runs, and hill sprints. You never want to jump into speedwork without preparing your muscles and body by gradually warming up. A warm-up should be very easy — run at a 1-3 on the RPE scale.

Cool Down

Cool down after any workout that involves changes in pace or effort levels. A cool-down should be very easy, run at a 1-2 on the RPE scale, and help bring your body back to baseline regarding breathing and heart rate.

Easy + Recovery Runs

Easy runs are nice and relaxed, run at conversation pace, coming in at a rate of perceived exertion of 2-3. The objective of these runs is to recover from harder sessions and add easy aerobic volume to your week.

Interval Workouts

Intervals are repeated efforts at a specific target pace with jogging or standing recoveries in between. They improve speed, form, and running economy by training at paces at or faster than your goal race pace. Each rep should be fast but controlled — if you can't hit the target pace on the final rep, start more conservatively next time.

Tempo + Threshold Runs

Tempo and threshold work is sustained running at a 'comfortably hard' effort — roughly the pace you could hold for an hour in a race. These sessions teach your body to clear lactate faster, which is the single biggest driver of race-day endurance at this distance.

Hill Sprints

Short, hard efforts uphill (or 30-45 seconds of fast running if you have no hills nearby). Hills build power and speed while keeping impact forces low. Walk or jog back down between reps — full recovery is the point.

Long Runs

Long runs gradually increase your volume, which is vital in preparing you for race day. Long runs should be run at an RPE of 3-4.

Strides

Strides are short accelerations in which you begin easy and increase your effort level to almost top speed, RPE 8-9, and then gradually return to your initial pace. You may run them at any point during the run. The rest of the run should be at an easy, conversational pace.

Rest Days

Rest days are not just a suggestion — they are a necessity. They are the days when you rest, hydrate, refuel, and relax, without any strenuous activity. Your body needs this time to adapt to your workouts and prevent injuries. Respect and prioritize rest days for better running performance.

Cross-Training

Where the plan offers cross-training, pick any low-impact aerobic activity you enjoy — cycling, swimming, elliptical, rowing. Keep the effort easy (RPE 2-3); the goal is aerobic work without running impact.

Shake Out Run

A shake-out run is a very easy jog, usually run the day before a race to "shake out" your legs. It should be a 1-2 on the RPE scale.

Strength Training

Strength training is not just a beneficial addition to your running plan — it plays a crucial role in correcting muscle imbalances, making you a fitter, stronger, faster runner, and helping you stay injury-free. Aim for two sessions per week, whenever you can fit them in. Incorporate compound exercises such as squats, lunges, glute bridges, calf raises, planks, push-ups, and rows.

CUSTOMIZING THE PLAN

No two runners are the same, and there's no such thing as a one-size-fits-all plan. Feel free to shuffle days to fit your weekly schedule (keep a rest or easy day between hard sessions), repeat a week if you need more time, and swap any workout you can't complete for an easy run.

MEDICAL DISCLAIMER

This plan is for informational purposes only; it is not a certified exercise / health / wellness regime. Partake in run training at your own risk, always consult a doctor before starting a new exercise regime, and don't do anything stupid. Now let's get on with the details...

QUESTIONS?

Check out our [RunClub community](#), — an awesome community of runners sharing their knowledge, frustrations, and wins!